

4 Results

4.1 Fact 1: Employment for young workers has declined in AI-exposed occupations

Consider software engineers and customer service agents, two occupations frequently considered to be highly exposed to generative AI tools. Media attention has raised the specter of widespread employment disruption for young software engineers (Thompson, 2025; Raman, 2025; Allen, 2025; Horowitch, 2025).

Figure 1 shows employment changes by age group for these occupations, normalized to 1 in October 2022. While the types of work and workers in each of these occupations differs in many ways, both occupations present a similar pattern: employment for the youngest workers declines considerably after 2022, while employment for other age groups continues to grow. By September 2025, employment for software developers aged 22-25 declined nearly 20% compared to its peak in late 2022. Figure A1 shows that a similar pattern holds for computer occupations and service clerks more generally.

Figure A2 shows four other professions as case studies, spanning varying levels of AI exposure according to Eloundou et al. (2024). Marketing and sales managers, in the fourth quintile of AI exposure, show a decline in employment for young workers much like the case of software and customer service, albeit with smaller magnitudes. Front-line production and operations supervisors, in quintile 3, show an increase in employment for young workers, though the growth in employment is smaller than the increase for workers over age 35.

In contrast, the trends for occupations that Eloundou et al. (2024) rated as less exposed do not fit the pattern of the more exposed occupations. Stock clerks and order fillers, in quintile 2, show no obvious difference by age. Strikingly, the series for health aides, comprising nursing aides, psychiatric aides, and home health aides, show a quite different trend from software or customer service: employment for young workers has been growing *faster* than for older workers.

Figure 2 shows these patterns hold more generally across professions. The top left plot shows a divergence in employment outcomes for more and less exposed occupations for workers aged 22-25, with more exposed occupations experiencing declining employment. For older age groups, we find